
THE SOLSTICE HARVEST — LEORA'S BIRTH

The room didn't feel like a celebration. It felt like a procedure that had finished correctly.

Leora had just been taken from Audr during the solstice ritual. Friedrich didn't even look at her for long. He didn't ask if she was healthy. He didn't ask what she looked like.

He only checked one thing.

That the cycle had completed.

That the Alraune transfer had happened.

That the system had "taken."

Everything else was irrelevant to him now.

The infant was placed in Friedhelm's arms.

He was three.

Too small to understand what he was being given, but old enough—somehow—for it to feel heavy. Not physically. Structurally. Like something had been assigned to him and there was no version of the world where he could put it down.

He looked at her like he was trying to understand what he was supposed to do with a life that had just been handed over unfinished.

Leora made a small sound. Not crying. Just presence.

She reached for him.

Her hand closed around his finger.

And Friedhelm froze.

Not fear.

Recognition.

Like something inside him had just locked into place.

Across the room, Wulf was sitting on the bed.

He saw her and stopped moving completely.

Like he couldn't decide if she was real.

Then he slowly shifted closer.

Not cautious.

Drawn.

Brunhild watched all of it.

She was already paying attention in a way most adults don't when they're trying to look composed.

She asked, simply,

"What's her name?"

Friedrich didn't answer.

He didn't care.

He was already done with the moment.

Without looking up he said,

"Friedhelm can name her."

That was it. He was already turning away from her in his mind.

Brunhild crouched beside Friedhelm.

"What do you think of her?"

Friedhelm looked down at the baby for a long time.

Leora didn't let go of his finger.

Finally he said,

"She's bright."

Wulf made a small, breathless sound from the bed—like that word meant something important.

Brunhild glanced at him.

“Bright? Like light?”

Wulf nodded too fast, like he agreed before he even understood why.

Friedhelm looked at him, then back at Leora.

“Yes,” he said. “Like a light.”

Brunhild nodded slowly, like she was testing the shape of the idea.

“Are there light names?”

That question changed the room a little.

It stopped being only ritual.

It became naming.

Brunhild started listing names softly—older names, northern names, names that sounded like weather and stone and warmth held in the body.

Friedhelm listened without interrupting.

At some point, he just said,

“Leora.”

It wasn’t dramatic.

It was certain.

Brunhild repeated it once, like she was confirming it belonged.

“Leora.”

And then nodded.

“That fits.”

The wet nurse arrived after that, an Alraune-appointed caretaker. She took the child carefully, like she already understood this wasn’t just another infant.

Brunhild leaned in and quietly told her the name.

Leora.

And then something else—softer, private, meant for no system and no record.

A second name.

A name only Brunhild, Friedhelm, and Wulf would ever use.

Friedrich didn't ask what it was.

He didn't care enough to ask.

He had already left the meaning of the moment behind.

BRUNHILD TEN BRINKEN

Brunhild is a Ten Brinken cousin, close enough to matter in lineage, distant enough not to be directly controlled by the main branch.

She carries herself like someone raised near war but not broken by it.

She is steady. Observant. Not loud, but never passive.

People tend to describe her in two ways:

- she feels like authority when she speaks
- and like judgment when she stays silent

She is one of the few people in the family who treats Friedhelm like a person instead of a function.

With Leora, she becomes something more complicated.

Not maternal in a soft sense.

More like protective recognition—like she understands what Leora is before anyone admits it out loud.

She is also the first person to seriously register that Leora's condition is not just inheritance, but pressure.

And that pressure can shift.